Data Entry and Keyboarding Skills

The big idea

Data entry means entering information into a computer accurately and quickly. The **keyboard** is the main tool for this. **Touch typing** – typing without looking at the keys, using all ten fingers – lets you work fast and with fewer errors. It is a key skill for jobs like data entry operator, customer support and office assistant.

The keyboard layout

Most keyboards use the **QWERTY** layout, named after the first six letters of the top letter row. It was designed by **Christopher Latham Sholes** for typewriters in the 1870s.

Key group	Keys	Use
Alphanumeric (typing) keys	Letters A–Z, numbers 0–9, symbols	Typing text
Function keys	F1–F12	Special tasks (F1 = Help, F2 = Rename, F5 = Refresh)
Control/modifier keys	Ctrl, Alt, Shift, Windows key, Esc	Used with other keys for shortcuts
Navigation (cursor) keys	Arrow keys, Home, End, Page Up, Page Down, Insert, Delete	Move the cursor
Numeric keypad	0–9 and +, –, *, / on the right	Fast number entry (turn on Num Lock)

Key group	Keys	Use
Special keys	Enter, Backspace, Tab, Caps Lock, Spacebar	Editing and formatting

The home row

The **home row** is the middle row of letters, where fingers rest when not typing.

- **Left hand**: little finger on **A**, ring on **S**, middle on **D**, index on **F**.
- **Right hand**: index on **J**, middle on **K**, ring on **L**, little on **;** (semicolon).
- **Thumbs** rest on the **spacebar**.

GUIDE KEYS

F and **J** have small raised bumps. They let you find the home row without looking. Index fingers always return to F and J.

Each finger reaches up or down to keys in its own column (e.g. the left index finger types F, G, R, T, V, B, 4, 5). The **top row** is QWERTYUIOP and the **bottom row** is ZXCVBNM.

Correct typing technique and posture

- Sit straight with your back supported and feet flat on the floor.
- Keep elbows at about 90°, wrists straight and slightly raised (not resting on the desk while typing).
- Monitor at eye level and about an arm's length away.
- Tap keys lightly; keep eyes on the screen or copy, not on the keyboard.
- Take short breaks; stretch hands and look away from the screen every 20 minutes.

SPEED BEFORE ACCURACY

Beginners often rush. Focus on **accuracy first**; speed improves naturally with practice. A fast typist with many errors is slower overall because of corrections.

Measuring typing skill

Typing speed is measured in **WPM (words per minute)**. A "word" is usually counted as **5 characters** (including spaces).
Gross WPM = (total characters typed ÷ 5) ÷ time in minutes.
Accuracy (%) = (correct words ÷ total words) × 100.

CALCULATE THE SPEED

You type 1,000 characters in 5 minutes. Words = 1000 ÷ 5 = 200. Speed = 200 ÷ 5 = **40 WPM**.

Typing tutor software

Rapid Typing Tutor, **TuxType**, **KTouch** and **Typing Master** offer lessons (home row, top row, bottom row, numbers), games and tests that show speed and accuracy. Start with home-row lessons, then add one row at a time.

Data entry tips

- Check the source document carefully; double-check numbers.
- Use the **numeric keypad** for numbers and **Tab** to move between fields.
- Save often (Ctrl+S) and verify entries before submitting.

EXAM TIP

Memorise the home-row finger positions (ASDF – JKL;) and that F and J are guide keys. These appear as MCQs every year.

Quick recap

- QWERTY layout; key groups: alphanumeric, function, modifier, navigation, numeric keypad, special.
- Home row: A S D F (left) J K L ; (right); F and J are guide keys.
- Good posture: straight back, feet flat, wrists straight, screen at eye level.
- Speed in WPM (5 characters = 1 word); accuracy first.

Practice questions

1. The home row keys for the left hand are
   (a) A, S, D, F (b) Q, W, E, R (c) Z, X, C, V (d) G, H, J, K
2. Which two keys have raised bumps to help find the home row?
   (a) A and ; (b) D and K (c) F and J (d) G and H
3. The QWERTY layout is named after
   (a) its inventor (b) the first six letters of the top letter row (c) a company (d) the home row keys
4. Typing speed is measured in
   (a) MBPS (b) RPM (c) DPI (d) WPM
5. A person types 1,500 characters in 5 minutes. The gross speed is
   (a) 30 WPM (b) 50 WPM (c) 60 WPM (d) 75 WPM
6. Which posture is correct while typing?
   (a) Bending forward close to the screen (b) Back straight, feet flat on the floor, wrists straight (c) Resting wrists on the desk edge while typing (d) Monitor placed well below chest level
7. The right little finger rests on which home row key?
   (a) L (b) K (c) J (d) ; (semicolon)
8. What is touch typing? Write two advantages.
9. Describe the correct posture for typing on a computer.

Answers: 1. a 2. c 3. b 4. d 5. c 6. b 7. d 8. see notes 9. see notes